

Theorizing Gender and Organizing

Silvia Gherardi, Judi Marshall, and Albert J. Mills

This chapter offers four voices – those of the three contributors and another, shared voice of commentary (this one) providing some structure and reflective sense making. The chapter was contentious to write for all three of us, and the dilemmas we faced seemed highly gender-associated. We rebelled against the proposed point-counterpoint approach to the book. For a long time we did not write, despite helpfully intended prompts and suggestions from an editor. We each felt guilty, but did not stir. Eventually Albert suggested an image of engaging, of doing the chapter “like a discussion group,” which drew Silvia and Judi in, as it reframed the potential process and therefore form. One person would start by making a comment and throwing out questions to the other two. And so we could move forward, in a “journey of discovery,” building on each others’ contributions rather than arguing competing positions. Albert volunteered to write the first piece if neither Silvia nor Judi objected. The next person would respond, and so on. We wanted to give “a real feel of debate” and a sense of reflective time between contributions.

Albert circulated his contribution. Silvia and Judi wrote responses, also introducing new themes. These latter two pieces overlapped in time, and Silvia’s was posted in two parts, with a pause between them. Each contribution commented both on issues of getting started, theorizing these through a gender lens, and more generally on themes of gender and organizing. How we started – that is, in resistance to an offered form of speaking – influences what we have generated, what approaches of the many available we have each taken to theorizing gender and organizing. Drawing together this collected dialog of e-mails, a draft chapter was shaped by Judi. This arranged the material under three headings reflecting different aspects of our conversations. It was then reviewed by all three of us, and further revised.

The chapter’s next section offers our reflections on the first topic heading of “getting

started”, working with gender, knowledge, and power. It elaborates our writing process. In each person’s contribution there were statements which expressed their perspective, interests, and positioning. These are collected in the following section, showing where we are each coming from. A further section draws out issues about gender and organizing, viewed through our different, mutually informing, lenses. Occasionally a contributor speaks briefly alongside another person’s voice, in closer commenting. These pieces were inserted during the final drafting, and so are not responded to in the text. They are in italics to show this different timing.

To show some of the background to this chapter, we quote from the editors’ original framing:

Gender issues in organization studies have had a short but vigorous history. Informed originally by the pragmatics of discrimination and segmentation and the concerns of feminist critique, the issues identified have increased dramatically in complexity and sophistication. A critical point in contemporary debates centres on the very conception of gender and its place and relevance in organizations and organization theory.

The editors went on to depict some of the wide variety of ways in which the field of gender and organizing is therefore approached, and the variety in what are then considered core issues and topics. The theme of how to think about gender is central below.

Theorizing our “Slowness” in Getting Started through a Gender Lens

Albert. For all three of us this chapter should be fairly straightforward. What could be easier than engaging in a dialog on gender and organizations? Certainly it is no accident that we three have been asked to collaborate on the paper. All three of us have spent much of our adult lives writing about some aspect of the subject. Yet there has been something problematic about the process. It has taken us

close to a year to begin to write. Perhaps it seemed too simple. Or perhaps too many other things overwhelmed us. But perhaps it was something else, something more personal and profound.

Judi. *Yes, and more political.*

Albert. I know that it did cross my mind that a paper on gender and organizations was doable at a later date. Yet on those occasions that I made time to think of what I was going to write I was hit with a number of emotions, reflections, and questions that weren't easy to marshal (pardon the pun) into a comprehensive semblance of order. Eventually, taking a leaf out of Judi's book (Marshall, 1984), it came to me that our emotions, reflections and questions were far more valuable as a starting point than any attempted nod at rationality and order. Perhaps in this way we can engage in a process of contributing to an understanding of gender and organizations that goes beyond any expected point and counterpoint.

My very first reflection is on the process of being asked to collaborate on this chapter. I am very flattered yet very troubled. I am flattered that someone should think me particularly knowledgeable ("an expert") on gender and organizations, but profoundly troubled that I am constantly engaged in a process that appears to disempower the voices of others. By authorizing certain actions and outcomes as "an area of study" I fear that we may be replacing one set of imposed subjectivities with another (Foucault, 1980). It is one thing to create "cultural dopes," yet another to contribute to the creation of gendered dupes, i.e., people whose gendered identities the gender expert knows "more fully" than they. It was a failure to put that concern to the forefront of my thinking that led to my arrogance in assuming that gender and organizations were an easy "subject" to write about. Of course, I am not the first to voice this concern. Jeff Hearn (1992: 65) sums up the problem well when he says that "organizational research . . . is no longer likely to be a distanced academic exercise, but one where the boundaries between the objects of research, research method, and personal life begin to break down." Nonetheless it is one thing to recognize the problem and another to avoid

it. The privileges of academic life and the requirements of research and writing impose conventions on the communication of ideas that have implications not only for how we "view" others but also for our own sense of identity in a modernist world. How do/should we deal with the problem of subverting power from within the privileged discourses of academic life? Specifically, how do we address gender inequities at work from a position that privileges some voices over others?

That brings me to the idea of "point and counterpoint" as a mode of discourse. Like you, I am used to challenging viewpoints that I perceive as encouraging discrimination. But this is different. Here are three feminist writers asked to debate the issues of gender and organization. Is it appropriate to engage in a style of debate where any disagreements could be understood in terms of the specific parameters of debate (i.e., a point followed by a counterpoint)? My personal answer is simply to bring the issue to the fore and share with each other and the reader that we see this more as a journey of discovery, a collaborative effort where we share our differences.

Silvia. I want to thank Albert, for two reasons. The first is that he took the courage to kick off the process of starting to write this chapter, that in my mind was becoming a nightmare, and the second reason is for starting by airing his emotions. It gives me a good excuse both for starting in the same way, and letting my feelings come out, and at the same time grounding my reasoning on a feminist methodological principle that continues to prove highly valuable despite the changing of the meanings of "feminism." *Let's start from our own experience* was the motto I learnt when first I came to practice feminism. Following it, I wish to share with you my reaction to the invitation made by the editors.

I have to confess that I was not flattered but annoyed by the subtitle *Point-Counterpoint*. My first thought was "My God, another boyish thing! Only men can be so excited by the idea of the war game. Either they do it with weapons or they do it with thought, but the pattern is always the same. The stage can be the monthly faculty meeting or the medieval crusade, but

the music is always the same! I'm fed up with it and refuse to be continually forced to play this game and will decline the invitation with a polite letter."

Immediately after, I realized how I was using gender stereotypes, casting all men as stupid warriors, forgetting how many women like the same game, and most of all I was thinking in terms of men and women as categories of people, assuming that the game was gendered! I felt so ashamed of myself, and so unprofessional as a gender scholar, that I had to admit that oppositional thinking is so deeply ingrained in our Western culture as to deserve some reflection and elaboration with a gender approach in mind. Therefore the editors hit the point and I sent them an abstract with this title "The privilege of an ironic perspective on gender and gendering." I had in mind to start from the statement the editors made when they invited a "text constructed around dyads of point and counterpoint, thesis to antithesis, paradigm against paradigm," and wonder whether a gender subtext was implicit in their claim to knowledge. At the time I didn't know that the three of us were expected to engage in a conversation.

Judi. Firstly, I find myself working on how I approach this task, as I see each of you doing. I *was* slow to write, partly because of too many other things to do, as Albert says. But there was also something more profound, more political, about the nature of knowing and how it is shaped, often unwittingly, by forms of expression. I was very influenced by my reaction *against* the initial framework suggested for each book chapter – debate, point, and counterpoint. This shaping of the way of doing knowledge offended me, as it did Silvia. I see form and epistemology as so closely associated.

What has happened so far has, I think, mirrored, and therefore been informative about, issues in theorizing (and living) gender and organizing. For me, stance (by which I don't mean something necessarily fixed or clear) is vitally important to any work on gender, and is reflected in the form or pattern of any writing on this topic. *How* we think about gender is often more important than the "content" of what we think – the epistemology is primary,

and it informs how ideas are held, and can then be used. (Berman: "*How* things are held in the mind is infinitely more important than *what* is in the mind, including this statement itself," 1990: 312.)

Being told, however flexibly intended, how to think and how to discuss gender with each other when we were invited to join this project created resistances for each of us. Whilst I had much empathy with the original rationale for the book – the "expressly polyvocal, multipositional text," I was especially concerned about the core notion of debates, the adversarial style proposed, the potential for polarized "either/or" thinking, the inherent notion of position taking. The original intention had been swiftly turned into a dominant, inherently suspect, form, leaving undisturbed (perhaps reinforced) some aspects of reasoning with epistemological and gender/power associations. I could not imagine speaking authentically, creatively, into such a structure, saw it as a *de facto* trap, was concerned about what we might be replicating. And I thought the notion of debate was inherently gender-biased, in a more "masculine ideal" image, with the potential to create differences in a negative way. Is there a parallel here with how difference, in gender and other terms, often has to be created through an active process, has to be made to arise from what is potentially more plurality of form? There are issues of politics, the nature of knowing and access to expression here. (Which Silvia explores below in connection with Italian feminists.)

We sought to renegotiate the contract, were understood and were granted a different format from other contributors – instead of "an oppositional point-counterpoint structure" we were to have a three person "round-table" format (editor's e-mail) – "partly in recognition of the fact that the debate format is masculinist in nature" (editor's e-mail). We were, however, encouraged still to have a "vigorous engagement" and each "to press their perspective strongly." We were being given cues about "good quality thinking" in a dominant mode. These sat uneasily for me. But I did not want to write a treatise on alternative ways of knowing (Belenky et al., 1986), valuable as these are to amplify the field: that would have been to

join in the polarizing. And so still we could not get started. Having rejected one form did not mean that we effortlessly created another. The parallels to the epistemology of working with gender echo strongly here. For example, whilst we may not want to become entangled in the limited choice of either consenting to or resisting dominant, male ideal, patterns of leadership, it is not so easy to create new possibilities in unoccupied space. Too often, styles imagined as alternative sound like stereotypes of women's qualities reproduced (Calás and Smircich, 1993).

So we have resisted the suggested form of this chapter, but I now feel more than slightly hesitant about how these sharp shafts of insight and positioning appear to be directed at the editors. I do not see it as personal, and trust they will not take it in that way, given their willingness to negotiate form. They are being used as an example of a general principle – and (tricky, this) they are also using and reinforcing dominant power to dictate format, and therefore shape epistemology, in this project. People wanting consistency is a (sometimes unwitting) way in which plurality is under threat these days. Are we, though, into point-counterpoint in our relationship with the editors rather than among ourselves, I wonder? And so should we be a little suspicious of ourselves? And, at the same time, I do agree that acknowledging our resistance feels as if it has opened the opportunities for a different way of engaging. A simple attention to process, and to not colluding in dominant forms, seems valuable, *and* to have had action consequences.

It was an issue for me too, Albert, that the contributors would be “leading exponents in the field.” This is both ego-massaging and elitist, privileging – perhaps encouraging me to take the sound of my own voice too seriously. Like you, it led me to reflect on whose voices get incorporated and whose “omitted” from “mainstream” discourse. Those who see the world other than as debate and as amenable to expression with sharp edges (a normative form) are not there, leaving the “central” field for those willing to engage on its terms – of whom there are still many, men and women. And so the dominant pattern of rhetoric is maintained.

But listening to the voices of those who choose to inhabit the margin is central to understanding gender and organizing. For example, in her writing hooks *shows* gender, race, and class intersecting, she does not just tell me that they do (e.g., hooks, 1989).

Another aspect of the invitation to be a “leading exponent” was that it invited me to self-monitor, to shape my behavior in ways which warrant/maintain this sense of implied (and will I ever believe it really?) membership in the elite of those who are invited to speak. A self-disciplining circularity here. In accepting the invitation I therefore censored my own queries about where I stand in the “field” of gender studies these days. I am *doing gender* in my scholarship, but at times it is a more interwoven, less overt, theme than it used to be. (An issue to which I return.) And so we enact here some of the processes of potential conformity which affect women, people from ethnic minorities, and others considered “different” in organizations.

Can we be part and apart, generally and in this setting? Silvia offers the possibility of irony, which delights me. Albert wonders if we can subvert power from within the privileged discourses of academic life. (“Yes!” I write in the margin. “And how can we achieve that here?”) These are questions I live with, which are part of my praxis (at least, my aspirations for praxis; I would not want to claim too much), as well as my thinking. I work, for example, with notions of multiple positioning, and also with the notion of “aware and chosen marginality” (Marshall, 1995), applying this self-injunction to my positioning both in mainstream *and* in potentially alternative cultures.

Starting writing in this more person-based way grounded us in engagement together. We exchanged e-mails appreciating each others’ contributions, and expressing warmth at the dialog. By finding an alternative process and form it did seem that we had created a culture of engagement which enacted mutuality, which we preferred to one of oppositions. It allowed us to be more fully ourselves and diverse, but also connected, bringing an expanding richness, and sometimes the value of agreement, to our conversation.

Overtly stating Aspects of our Perspectives

Some of our e-mail contributions were saying who we are, how we came to the approaches we have, and how we hold our ideas. These are three stories from a multiplicity of potential paths to wanting, needing, to understand gender and organizing in some of its multidimensional complexity.

Albert. Now, in my opening section I said "three feminists," and I should deal with that issue and all that it entails. It is almost certainly problematic that I should choose to label you both – you may want to approach the issue with a different voice, so my apologies. It is also problematic that I choose to encase us all in an all-inclusive yet profoundly exclusive term: we are "in," others are not "in." Here I apologize to anyone reading this who may see my use of the term "feminist," however intended, as something privileging one group of people. Profoundly, of course, we come to the question of men in feminism (cf. Jardine and Smith, 1987). To begin with, there is the question of the label itself. Can a man be a feminist? My own preference for dealing with this problem has been to characterize my approach as "aspirational feminist" (Mills, 1994): "It is aspirational in that it (i) recognizes the limitations of 'male' experience in trying to represent 'female' experience and (ii) attempts to avoid notions of (political) correctness and closure of debate by suggesting that a (male) feminist position is something to be constantly striven for." Jeff Hearn has taken this much further by focusing on men and masculinities in the making of discriminatory environments (cf. Collinson and Hearn, 1994, 1996; Hearn, 1992, 2001).

Silvia. In reading Albert's remarks [that is, material developed in the following section] I had the feeling that "organizations" are not so crucial for him, as if they are only the stage for gender relations. While what was challenging his desire to understand more or better is gender and he links gender to inequities at work and discrimination. I see his line of reasoning and can easily follow it, and trace it in the

discourses which frame gender as constructed in relations of power and dominance. In understanding his position I understand better my tacit representation of gender and my intellectual journey into feminism. In mirroring myself into his reasoning I became able to see how my understanding of gender is more linked to knowledge than to power, albeit both are interdependent.

For me the mirror symbolizes how we understand and account for similarity and difference. And the image of the mirror recalled for me the feminist appropriation of the archetype of the witch. The witch in early feminism was the symbol of female knowing, of women being in relation with nature, the body, herbs, and the oral transmission of their knowledge in a matrilineal genealogy. Feminist historians studying medieval processes attributed to witches the cultural representation of a way of knowing which tried to escape the control of men, the Church and official medicine. When, in my experience, Italian feminists were on the streets striving for the legalization of abortion and were crying, "Tremate, tremate, le streghe son tornate" (Quake, quake, the witches are back!), they were giving voice to a suppressed knowledge, to a reappropriation of the body and sexuality and were also representing themselves as the living embodiment of men's fear of women. The witch is the symbol of the woman who releases herself from man's control and male culture. A counterculture was the historical answer to the question "Who, what, is a woman?" (Albert's question) in feminist theorizing on knowledge in the 1970s. The unity of the Cartesian subject was delegitimized by another subject who posed herself as "An Other Knower." Therefore in my historically situated grasping of the category of "gender" it came to represent another methodological principle, represented by the question: whose knowledge is considered legitimate and whose is heretical? Gender for me has to do primarily with the politics of knowledge and the opposition to any official truth. The reappropriation of the body represented also a bodily grounded way of knowing and the transition from an object of pleasure to a subject of pleasure (i.e. aesthetics and eroticism as modes of knowing the world).

Judi. *Silvia, your reflections offer a sense of how some feminist positions on theorizing have emerged, and what they may contribute as themes and suspicions to understanding gender and organizing. By telling this story of your development you tacitly ask anyone in this field, and the reader, "How have you come to hold the ideas you do, in the ways you do?" And this journey of development will then shape those ideas. My sense is that there are significantly different groundings for North American and European feminists from different countries.*

Judi. Albert, feminist is one of my identities, but not my only self-description these days, rather one among many. In fact I do not want one identity, or too much clarity of this kind. I want to range widely, occupying different perspectives as they seem "appropriate." If I were to choose a root, it would have to be critical action inquiry or something like that; it would have to be a process.

I like you opening with *starting from our own experience*, Silvia, which I concur with as fundamental. This relates to Albert's suggestion that we note and work with the interconnections of lives, theorizing, and inquiry. (I just want to refute any implication that life is "personal" and separate from theory or inquiry – a gender-associated polarization. What I am as an academic/practitioner/person is thoroughly integrated.) As you move into notions of giving voice to suppressed knowledge I associate with that too, and see it as a major life task I have set myself (perhaps not always consciously). This does not necessarily carry the headline "gender," because that is often less important to me than pointing to broader horizons – such as ecology, social justice, a deeper sense of generative humanity. (These are obviously highly gender-associated.) And so I work to expand, ground, develop notions of inquiry and systemic thinking (for example, in my "Living life as inquiry" article, Marshall, 1999). I see myself as willingly, willfully, working with processes which have been gender-associated and devalued, seeking to re-claim and reintegrate them – in my own living practice and in my ways of thinking.

Silvia. *I would like to stress that any "feminism" is first of all a practice – and a political*

practice – on which a theory is grounded. No "armchair theorizing" can be done on gender relations!

Judi. For me, theorizing organizational life requires an active scanning of possible approaches to sense making, combining a multiplicity of frames, a richness of possible perspectives. This includes moving between focusing in on gender – drawing on a plurality of feminist positions – and defocusing gender as more generic issues such as power, the dynamics of inclusion/exclusion, and so on, become figural. And we need to incorporate multiple frames on difference – gender, race, class, and more (Collins, 1990; hooks, 1989). This could be described as a "both/and" approach, but I balk at such a descriptor, it sounds too harmonious, balanced, easy to achieve. I have a strong, jangling imagery here, challenging, politically aware, distinctions sharp, not blurred, robust. So, in any thinking or praxis, my question is *In what ways are gender, race, aspects of difference, at issue here?*

I am seeking to work in multiple perspectives, rather than to achieve a reconciliation of supposed opposites, because I believe we need complexity of understanding to appreciate complexity of phenomena (what Bateson, 1973, calls learning level III and Ashby the law of requisite variety, Conant and Ashby, 1970). This could allow us to transcend or circumvent the polarized, either/or reasoning of much gender discussion. Invoking plurality leads me to how much I value your work, Silvia and Albert, and what each of you has contributed to my ways of working with gender. And it reminds me of some other people whose contributions could be in here – for example, the incisive unwillingness to be fooled of Marta Calás and Linda Smircich (1993), and the persistence with which Joanne Martin points to how gender is embedded, including in the theorizing and practices of organizational studies (Martin, 2000).

Using the space of this chapter to enact pluralism seems a more appreciative approach than fighting each other, but I do not advocate it to avoid critical analysis, rather as a generative, integrative, form of critical analysis. (There seems a common thread here, Silvia, with your exploration of irony, below, about whether

critique is inherently suspect, or can be done differently.)

And so we move on to the third main area we addressed, which has already been foreshadowed above, that of how to theorize gender and organizing.

Exploring Issues of Gender and Organizing

Albert. The possibility of even an aspirational feminist approach depends in large part on the way the "subject" of the debate is understood. I'm referring to the ongoing debate among "feminist organizational analysts" concerning whether the focus is on "women" *per se* or on "gender" (Calás and Smircich, 1996). What actually are we studying when we analyze the relationship between organization and gender? For some it is about identifying and addressing those workplace processes that discriminate against women. Judi's book on women managers (Marshall, 1984: back cover), for example, "looks at the assumptions that are made about women's worth and how these commonly accepted assumptions affect our judgment about whether women could, or should, become good managers."

Judi. *Interesting that you should quote that. It now feels to me a sign of its time, of sense making then unfolding, and so only part of the picture. Analyses have become more multilayered, complex, rich, and detailed. Now I would talk more about gender, also, as embedded and enacted process.*

Albert. For some it is about identifying how "organizational factors" contribute to the social construction of gendered persons and the implications for individuals and organizations. Rosabeth Moss Kanter's (1977) work on men and women in corporate life, for example, explores how discriminatory organizational structures inhibit both the progress of female (and some male) employees and their potential contribution to the organizational ends (e.g., growth, profitability, etc.). While Silvia's work on gender, symbolism, and organizational cultures "explores the 'symbolic order' of gender in organizations – looking at how gender relations are culturally and discursively

produced and reproduced, and how they might be 'done' differently" (Gherardi, 1995: back cover). Sometimes a focus on gender is complementary to a "women-centered" approach, where gender is seen as "culturally specific patterns of behavior that may be attached to the (biological) sexes" (Oakley, 1972). But in some gender studies discussion of "women" is viewed as essentialist (cf. Rakow, 1986).

My own concern over the years has centered on whether a focus on discrimination against women (see, for example, Mills and Murgatroyd, 1991) ultimately reinforces the notion of difference, of women as "Other." But I have had an equal concern that the deconstruction of women (and men) will undermine the political agenda of addressing gender discrimination at work (see, for example, Wicks and Mills, 2000). Two incidents over the years have heightened my disquiet. One involved the name change of the Women in Management to the Gender and Diversity Division of the (US) Academy of Management in the mid 1990s. The other event, also in the mid 1990s, involved the firing of a "transsexual" from the Vancouver Rape Relief Society. The first event, initiated on the grounds that a "women in management" focus was too narrow in concept, left me, nonetheless, concerned that we may have lost a political space where women or "women" could define their "own" issues. Debatably, a focus on gender and diversity is more vague as to its political agenda and the role of "women" in that agenda. [I also, despite my own work (cf. Mills, 1998), share the concern that a focus on men and masculinities may push concern with "women" to the background.]

Judi. *Yes. I share your concern about losing political spaces, whilst I do not want only women-only spaces. The increasing use of diversity language is contributing to this loss of political space in many arenas, although offering valuable contributions of its own.*

Silvia. *My concern is different. I am more concerned with the invisible masculinity that "women's studies" in a sense helps to reproduce. I feel uncomfortable with the focus on "women" or the equation "sex = gender" and "gender = women." It looks like the only persons with gender are the women. These are not only misunderstandings due*

to inexperience or to a linguistic operation which attenuates the social embarrassment caused by the word 'sex,' replacing it with a more 'polite' one. They are an ideological operation which allows gender studies to continue without calling the gender relation – that is, the relation between the male and the female, men and women, masculine and feminine – into question. In this manner, maleness is made invisible, removed from critical reflection, and continues to be the prime term, the one in relation to which the other is defined by default. Gender is a relational concept, which calls into question men and women, and social practices of gender relations. Albert's example of the Rape Relief Society (below) is a good example of how gender is "done" in concrete organizational practices.

Judi. *I very much share the concerns you both express about replicating, often unintentionally, dominant forms of power relations.*

Albert. The second event raises profound questions about gender, embodiment, and gender politics. According to a press report, "Kimberly Nixon, who has undergone surgery and has been living as a woman for about 20 years, volunteered in 1995 to be a crisis counsellor with the Vancouver Rape Relief Society." A center coordinator asked her to leave, and she renegotiate redress through the British Columbia Human Rights Tribunal. Testifying at the tribunal in December 2000, Judy Rebeck, the former president of Canada's National Action Committee on the Status of Women, argued in favor of the Rape Center: "The issue at stake is whether a women's group has the right to decide who its members are" (quoted in Bailey, 2000). She went on to state that:

The challenge is, "Who is a woman"? . . . What makes this tense is, there's no question that transgendered people suffer from discrimination, they suffer a great deal. So, of course, [in] your heart as a feminist you want to be on their side in every fight but you can't because there is a conflict of rights. It goes to the very heart of what the women's movement is and what feminism is. It's a very important discussion and a difficult one. I have a reputation of always being on the side of the most oppressed women, but here the question is "Who is a woman?" It's a different kind of question" (Quoted in Bailey, 2000)

This shifts debate from "What is a woman?" (How are specific notions of women and men socially constructed?) to "Who is a woman?" (Who or what is "the subject" in gendering organizations?). For me the Vancouver case raises a number of issues about the relationship between discriminatory practices, embodiment, experience, and political action. If political action hinges on collective struggle against discrimination, what determines the basis of collective action? A shared sense of embodiment? [This would include all those labeled "women," including transgendered persons.] And/or a sense of shared experience based on the assumption of shared embodiment? [In terms of female being, this might exclude transgendered persons from some types of experience, such as menstruation, for example.] These issues are not insurmountable, but they are vexing and need careful consideration.

Finally, I want to revisit the issue of why "the organizational context" should be of interest to feminists. This is probably much more of an issue for those focused on the social construction of gender than for those scholars who are interested in women and organizational discrimination. In the latter case, a solid argument can be made for the pervasiveness of organizations in the lives of us all (Denhardt, 1981). Organizational life is not just a special case. Organizations are central to the structuring of relations in society, and their influence (e.g., economic structuring, advertising images, job status, and class) often reaches far beyond their own particular boundaries. Workplace discrimination is misnamed, because it has ramifications not only for hiring and promotion at a particular job site but also for assumptions about women's worth in society as a whole. Arguably, if too few organizations employ females at anything but the lower levels this contributes to a general sense of women's worth (cf. Abella, 1984). But the powerful impact of organizational life is not really in question: the debate is around how much weight we should place on organizations, in contrast to, say, the structuring of work (Armstrong and Armstrong, 1990), or the patriarchal family (Wolff, 1977). There are those who argue that organizations, as local "sites of sexuality" (Burrell, 1992), play

a unique role in the social construction of gender. Kanter's (1977) work is a prime example. This approach does not discount broader societal influence but, rather, contends that organizational dynamics bring about unique configurations of gender construction and experience. In contrast, there are those who argue for the primacy of "pre-existing gendered relationships," contending that "organizational forms . . . are inevitably shaped by a wide variety of social forces, gender notably amongst them. Organizations are the embodiment of different forms of patriarchal power relations . . ." (Witz and Savage, 1992: 57). And then there are those feminist scholars who give more or less equal weighting to organizational and extraorganizational factors, particularly those involved in the work-family debate (Haas et al., 1999; Lewis and Lewis, 1996). As I have argued elsewhere (Mills, 1997), my own preference is to argue for the primacy of organizational dynamics, but I wanted to raise the issue to indicate some of the epistemological difficulties raised with the study of gender and organizations.

In short, far from being simple, study of the relationship between gender and organization raises profound questions about the role and identity of the researcher, the relationship between feminism and academic discourse, the subject and the field of enquiry.

Judi. Albert, your input shows how wide the boundaries of the potential field and issues we might consider are, and the difficulty of doing them justice here. I hope we have exemplified some critical issues about how to think about gender and organizing so that readers can apply their own versions to any material in this field.

I like your suggestion that we should appreciate the interconnectedness of aspects of this field, especially those of the researcher, method, and field of inquiry.

I appreciate the several ways in which political awareness appears in your section, for example, noting the possible loss of political space if we move into the language of diversity. I agree. (And diversity as a label can also have its benefits. It is sometimes more acceptable as an educational invitation – for example,

allowing me to raise issues of masculinity with MBA students, who may not quite expect it – opening up space which I might not access if labeled feminist and talking about women.) Another example of potential political erosion is the incorporation of "tame" bits of gender awareness into organizational theorizing. For example, some of the popular management literature on men, women, and communication has appeal, and could be opening up gender understanding. But it seems limited in its appreciation of power and of its own meaning making, and so could reinforce old stereotypes rather than help people understand gender as complex and processual. Tannen (1991), for example, depicts men as more often into the language of status and women into the language of relationship. She claims these as equal but different. But this ignores the likely dynamic that status language will seek precedence over other forms. So the theorizing risks reinforcing dominant value patterns, not only about the relative merits of different codes of behavior but where women and men are positioned by them.

Finally, for now, I want to explore an issue that concerns me greatly – the replication of power-gender-knowing patterning, which seems so often to occur despite attempts at creating new initiatives. (Our concerns about the book's debate format were about this too.) I will illustrate from my current work.

During the last five years much of my time and energy has been devoted to developing, tutoring, and administering the M.Sc. in Responsibility and Business Practice we initiated at the University of Bath (in partnership with the New Academy of Business) in 1997. It is a two-year, part-time, action research-based degree, inviting participants to explore the challenges of integrating concern for ecology, social justice, and ethics with more established notions of organizational purposes. The (vast) territory of the degree is riddled with issues linked to gender, and to the devaluing of some aspects of human and ecological functioning relative to others. The power of dominant economic mind sets is, for example, readily apparent in many fields.

I wonder whether in this developing territory gender-power patterns are open to revision or

are being recreated. My sense is that both revision and replication are happening, and I am concerned that the latter appears extremely powerful. Much is *apparently* changing, for example, with increasing corporate attention to sustainability, social responsibility, and such issues. I think we need radical change, not just adjustments within mind sets. But how can I know *how* this might come about? Does it matter that (white) men's voices, many from the United States, already dominate this field? I would prefer to see pluralism. Does it matter that gurus – of sustainability, social justice, corporate responsibility – seem to be appearing? Is this a replication of hierarchic leadership, which I think we need to escape as a dominant pattern? What concerns me even more is the replication I see of the primacy of currently dominant forms of knowing, favoring intellectual, value-neutral knowing, seeking control. In these initiatives to live differently on the planet and in a global community we especially need to engage in multidimensional, whole-self, connected knowing – I believe. These are all gender-associated issues.

Silvia. I am reading the near-final draft of our contribution on the balcony of my summer house near Genoa the day after the end of the G-8 meeting held here. Judi's concern about the replication of dominant forms of thinking, acting, and knowing links with the discussions of these days in the antiglobalization debate. In fact it is more and more evident that other voices, other knowledges, other practices urge to be heard and want to be heard in a nonviolent context. At the same time it is paradoxical to claim for plurality and inclusion in the place where the first death occurred in confrontation around globalization.

Judi. My understandings of gender and organizing are nothing to me if they do not enable me to act with integrity and creativity in the space of this new degree and similar ventures, and in my everyday practice in my organizational, and other, life roles.

Silvia returned to her interest in offering irony as a choice beyond oppositional thinking. This is a major part of her contribution to the discussion, highly appropriate and playfully serious, and so it is reproduced here fully.

There are two parallel framing statements for this offering. In her original reply to the Editors' invitation, Silvia wrote:

Silvia. My intention is to show the similarities between the so-called gender trap (the impossibility of stepping out from gender, or of defining gender as "positive") and critical thinking. I want to pose the question: is a critique possible which produces new meanings, which opens and produces insights instead of new power games? In order to answer that question I'll point to one possible solution – "irony." (Another possibility is "situated knowledge.")

In the text itself, leading on from part one of her contribution, Silvia wrote:

Silvia. At this point I had to interrupt myself. A lot of time had passed since writing the previous paragraphs, I received Judi's contribution, and I could not continue writing as if nothing had happened. In reading Judi's words I was impressed by a common underlying understanding: feminism is not only a theory, but is mainly a practice. And it is a collective practice. I wish to take up Judi's phrase: "aware and chosen marginality" (Marshall, 1995). Even if I do not know the article Judi refers to, I would like to elaborate on producing knowledge from the margins (i.e., far from the mainstream).

Feminist theory (assuming for a moment that there is something like a unified feminism!) represents a theory of knowledge critical of any mainstream, foundational, and universal knowledge.

French and Italian feminism view the body as the symbolic rather than the physical origin of the subject "woman." This subject is unable to "auto-signify herself" because Western philosophical thought has imposed itself as male thought, devising a universal and neutral subject which defines and represents the world in its own terms. As a consequence, women have been denied access to the symbolic. A "woman" is a paradox, present and absent from language. The metaphor of the eccentric subject denotes a subject aware of constituting itself in an ever-becoming history, in an interpretation and

rewriting of self based on another cognition of society and culture. This subject is eccentric with respect to the social field, to institutional devices, to the symbolic, to language itself. It is a subject that simultaneously responds to and resists the discourses that interpellate it. The eccentric subject is capable of multiple identifications and belongings, but also of disidentification and displacements. The eccentric subject is not immune or external to gender, but is distant, critical, ironic, excessive. Feminism therefore takes a reflexive stance on the constitution of subjectivities in and through language and social practices of knowledge production.

Distrust in any claim to universal knowledge, suspicion in representations which try to fix a normative subjectivity for women, everyday practices which witness the political of the personal, are mundane traits of practicing feminism.

Other images try to capture the idea of a subject which is at the very same time internal to the language which produced it and resistant to it: the semiotic and the abject (Kristeva, 1977), the divine (Irigaray, 1982), the post-colonial (Spivak, 1987), the cyborg (Haraway, 1990), the lesbian (Wittig, 1992), the nomadic subject (Braidotti, 1994). In so doing, feminist thought produced the cultural effect of delegitimizing the unity and stability of the Cartesian subject. There emerges a strengthened difference which evades hegemonic thought. The subject thus defined traces knowledge itineraries through multiple points of intersection: differences between men and women, differences among women, differences within men. The politics of knowledge that derives therefrom is, in the words of Rosi Braidotti (1994), a set of conceptual trajectories that constitute a plural and open project: a polyphonic game of multiplicity.

An ironic, nomadic, eccentric knowing subject resists integration into mainstream disciplinary knowledge, but not from a desire for isolating but for producing knowledge from the margins and retaining a reflexive theoretical stance on the practices of knowledge production both in the mainstream and at its margins. Marginal practices retain the power of undermining local stability and insinuate

suspicion in taken-for-granted *habitus*, beliefs, and meanings. Irony, transgression, hypocrisy, subversion of gender codes may be considered as marginal practices undermining the stability of gender order and introducing playfulness in gender performances.

For me the meaning of staying at the margins is not only to be critical of the mainstream, but also to be in a liminal position, in a position of transgressing the boundaries, not recognizing the legitimacy of the borders. We can also transgress by flouting transgressive models: by emphasizing our female appearance, by exploiting gender privileges, exploring gender as a game. Hypocrisy protects the explorer and the innovator by providing symbolic substitutes. Can hypocritical endorsement of gender relations create room for experimentation by people of different sexes jointly in search of solutions? Can it help them feel more at ease in their sexed bodies? If so, complicity may be a bond which reveals the contradictions between gender as we think and want it, and gender as we do it. Exposing contradictions without claiming to resolve them is the prerequisite of a Socratic attitude towards self-knowledge based on irony as its resource.

Irony, as a metacommunicative resource, as an instrument of resistance, as a post-modern attitude, has undergone a renaissance in recent years. The pragmatics of irony is the destabilization in gender arrangements that ironic discourse can produce. Irony, in fact, insinuates doubt. It suggests that the world can be described in different terms, but it does not propose these other terms as alternative, "better," "more correct," or "truer." Irony is a processual invitation; an invitation to consider how things (gender relations, for example) can be redefined; how common sense can be problematized. Irony does not offer solutions; instead, it calls the linguistic games which produce a certain vision of the world into question.

Irony thus becomes a valuable resource when gender must be positioned within discursive practices and when a description of a male-centered world is to be contrasted with a female-centered one. The awareness of gender trap and linguistic trap are intertwined. Awareness of a choice among several vocabularies, of

the contingency and fragility of each of them, of the historicity of the affirmation of one rather than the other, of the nonneutrality of linguistic games, produces an ironist.

Every discourse at the same time allows some possibilities and disallows others: the ironic touch stresses the possibility of switching from one discourse to another, of casting doubt on the rules and procedures which govern a discourse and the relations between language and people. An ironist is not a good player in the "point-counterpoint" game, since her/his commitment to the game is too low!

Judi. *Silvia, I am delighting in how irony dis-entangles you, and me when I take this approach. And also you are stirring some of my repeated concerns as I look at some forms of current theorizing, especially those which are more deconstructive. Astute and valuable as they are, I worry that they are not enough alone. They may take us too far away from practice, and from the close alliance between theorizing and practising. I see dangers of cynicism, detachment, of an appreciation of multiple perspectives and therefore no willingness or need to take sides on issues, such as those of social and ecological justice. Can irony sometimes be the comfortable retreat of the intellectual? Is it a robust basis for praxis?*

Silvia. We are the products of a discourse while at the same time we produce discourses, but we can introduce the instability of these categories into our discourses. We can play with them, try to see the world differently by changing positions, lay bare the power relations which tie us to a discursive position. Of course, to convey an ironic message we must be self-ironic, we must also cast doubt on our own final vocabulary. That is to say, we must not take ourselves too seriously, and we must stop believing that we have direct access to the truth. This conflicts, for example, with that brand of feminism that asserts a truth principle – male domination – from which it derives a political consequence. Perhaps the political nature of irony is not as evident as a political program, but it undermines the foundations of all power based on the monopoly of absolute truth. As all totalitarian regimes (discourses) well know, it is impossible to respect a power structure which makes you laugh.

Irony as a communicative frame raises doubts over the truth and seriousness of what is asserted. Irony may therefore be employed as an offensive or a defensive maneuver in interaction. I would like to be able to develop a dialog as three ironists who have been invited to take seriously a knowing practice which they cannot take into serious consideration but do not want to offend their hosts. We are kept in a double bind, that's why we started writing by saying that we were unable to write. Ciao!

Here we closed the discussion, with many issues left open to further exploration. We had each dealt with the dilemmas and opportunities of writing in our own register of speaking, reflecting our own life processes of working with gender as both ideas and practice, and had offered these in conversation, giving some sense of a polyphony of styles, views, and lives lived. We thank the editors for bringing us together.

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